A Fragile Foundation

Basic attitudes toward the SED did not change with Stalin's death on 5 March 1953. What did change, though, was Moscow's attitude towards Ulbricht's disastrous reforms which were roundly criticised by a new power group revolving around Soviet Prime Minister Georgy Malenkov and KGB chief, Lavrentiy Beria.

During April and May, Stalin's heirs repeatedly warned Ulbricht to soften his reforms, but without success. As a result, on 5 June, Beria went for the jugular and gave Ulbricht a final warning to implement a 'New Course' and ditch reforms instigated the previous year. Aware that Beria considered Ulbricht to be a woolly-headed 'idiot' – several old hands in the SED Politburo felt secure enough to support Moscow. Among them, Beria's confidante Rudolf Herrnstadt, editor-in-chief of Neues Deutschland, the party daily, Wilhelm Zaisser, the GDR Minister of State Security, Anton Ackermann and Fred Oelssner. These men, and others, had long mouthed anti-Ulbricht sentiments and duly lined up to launch a carefully orchestrated broadside.

After being verbally mauled by the group, Ulbricht approved a reversal of policy by promising relief to hard-pressed farmers and an easing of anti-church measures but oddly, the unpopular 10 per cent rise in production quotas was kept in place, leaving workers furious.

It was in this ugly atmosphere that the first main crisis of the SED began to unfold. On 13 June, builders in East Berlin began slow-downs, followed two days later, on 15 June, by the dispatch of a small deposition to protest to aides of Otto Grotewohl – but there was no response. 'Anger,' one worker observed, 'was the emotion that dominates all others.' Feeling ignored and dejected, the next morning – 16 June 1953 – builders at Stalin Allee – East Berlin's most prestigious building project – along with workers at a new hospital in Friedrichshain, downed tools and took to the streets to demonstrate. As the number of protesters grew, they kept up an almost solid